

Just Not There

Life is a bra strap? Hangover Zen coincides with bouts of drunkenness? Bring on the eye-rolling and dry gagging. It's chick lit at its least chic.



YOU ARE HERE
by MEENAKSHI REDDY MADHAVAN
Penguin
Price: Rs 199
Pages: 255

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Okay. Here's the thing. Chick lit, as any compulsive consumer will tell you, is meant to make you feel fabulous. Girls named Lauren or Becky, fresh off the boat from the mid-west America or suburban England, float into big cities, determined to snag themselves some gorgeous men and even more gorgeous shoes and handbags, transforming themselves into Park Avenue princesses in racy reads with glossy pink covers. The plucky heroine starts out as a struggler, goes on to show a metaphoric finger to her mean woman boss/useless boyfriend, and ends up as a role model for anyone who has ever dreamed of getting the guy, the Manhattan loft (and lifestyle) and the luxe bedsheets with a thread count of 1,000 and more. And even if she doesn't, she learns valuable Lessons that will Last a Lifetime, on par with the best of Rhonda Byrne and Oprah Winfrey. It is important that such lessons are imparted in capital letters (to underline their absolute importance) and along with fortune cookie wisdom, some practical tips about the right underwear, the perfect kissing technique, and sometimes even the absolute best thing to say to

the fat boss in the corner office.

It's a formula as old as Jane Austen and it almost always works. Indian women have discovered it rather late in their literate lives but now it appears they are trying to make up in speed what they cannot in skill. The world finds the prospect exotic—a single urban Indian woman with an active sex life is right up there in the roster of ethnic chic with a caparisoned elephant and the Taj Mahal. So every time there's a new girls' novelette out there on the shelves, there's a frisson of excitement.



SAURABH SINGH

Which explains why young Meenakshi Reddy Madhavan's way-too-precisely titled *You Are Here* comes with such a blaze of advance hype. Smart, saucy, singleton makes out with a variety of men and then gets to write about it too. Heaven, on high heels?

Not exactly. *You Are Here* swings from a cocaine overdose at Elevate to a drunken night at Turquoise Cottage and lurches to a pool party in a Gurgaon farmhouse—all familiar landmarks to young Delhi women of a certain age who hold down hard-nosed jobs while simultaneously fending off small-town parents who want them married from the age of 18. *You Are Here's* heroine is lucky—her parents are divorced and determinedly liberal. But she's not so lucky in love—the boy she loves is rich, dishy and decidedly commitment-phobic. The problem is we realise this fairly early in the novel and not all the riffs the writer dispenses, ranging from the state of her underwear to the correct phone protocol for a Saturday night date, save it from veering from yawn to yuck (the heroine feels a flutter in her panties? Her life is like a bra strap? Ugh.). The heroine is not charming enough and her Ice Prince boyfriend not caddish enough. And not all the substituting of Chardonnay with Sula and self-help books with the Wise Voice of Mother (oops! This capital letters virus is contagious) can save the book from being a could-have-been.

In a season that has produced Anuja Chauhan's *The Zoya Factor* and Anita Jain's *Marrying Anita*, at least one thing is clear. Women writers age well. Clearly the best chick lit is written by hens, not chicks. Living a little is guaranteed to improve one's writing. *You Are Here* is so not there. ■

NEW RELEASES



ALI'S WORLD
by BADAL AND SWAPNA MUKHOPADHYAY
Roli Books
Price: Rs 995
Pages: 96

Nostalgia leaps from the book's pages as Ali a.k.a. Arpan Mukhopadhyay's parents narrate his story. Ali was an unusual boy, endowed with a special talent, whose life was cruelly cut short just when he was blossoming into a great painter.



SUSTAINING INDIA'S GROWTH MIRACLE
Edited by JAGDISH N. BHAGWATI AND CHARLES W. CALOMIRIS
Stanza
Price: Rs 495; Pages: 262

An analysis of the forces behind India's emergence as a world economic power. The book also identifies the weaknesses of the country's economy. It is a valuable guide for practitioners, policymakers, students and scholars.



DOING BUSINESS IN 21st CENTURY INDIA
by GUNJAN BAGLA
Business Plus
Price: Rs 495; Pages: 254

This practical guide to business in the Indian subcontinent maps out a route to avoid the pitfalls that can trap an unwary businessman here. It has everything one needs to know to understand and succeed in Indian market.